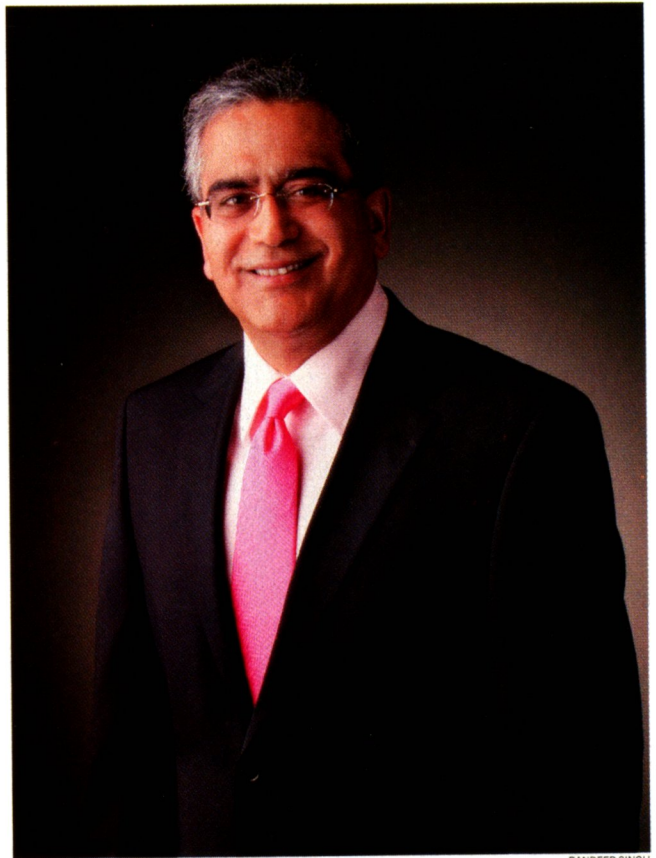


Great is a highly overused term in today's inflationary India. It could be a victory against Australia. A speech at a political rally, or even a movie at a multiplex. In this cacophony, perhaps it's time to pause on the nature of greatness. Is it the quality that allows a man to counter physical force with moral force, like Mahatma Gandhi? Is it the quality that propels a man to go against his own community and combat its orthodoxy, like Raja Ram Mohan Roy? Is it the quality that forces a man to find the warm heart of cold capitalism, like J.R.D. Tata? Or is it the faith that can, as Martin Luther King said, hew a stone of hope out of the mountain of despair and transform the jangling discords of a nation into a symphony of brotherhood?

As India enters the 61st year of its existence, we explore the essence of greatness in this special issue. What is it that makes a man, or a woman, decide not to give up, to never be satisfied, to always overcome? India's existence, its vibrant, though sometimes extreme, democracy, is a result of these greats. These builders of modern India have survived jail cells to ensure its freedom; excelled their own best to bring home sporting trophies; dug deep into their reserves to leave an intellectual inheritance that their nation can be proud of.

It wasn't easy selecting the 60 greatest Indians of the 20th century. INDIA TODAY's editors debated the names over several rounds of heated discussions, throwing out some names, including others. We decided that was not enough. It was time to assess what contemporary India thought of these greats. We devised a poll, that ran for three weeks, inviting responses by email and SMS. Thousands of entries poured in and the results, I have to tell you, took me by surprise. Bhagat Singh emerged the winner, trailed closely by Subhas Chandra Bose and less closely by Mahatma Gandhi. Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel, always second best to Jawaharlal Nehru, came in at No. 4 with 8 per cent of the votes, compared to just 2 per cent for his famous rival. Oddly again, Jayaprakash Narayan, a man who did the most in India's recent history to defend its freedom, got the least number of votes, just 145.

What does it say about India in the 21st century? I think a lot. It reflects the attitudes of our youthful population. Both Bhagat Singh and Bose are examples of a more confident nationalism, a more aggressive assertion of their sense of self and country. Above all, it shows an impatience with the status quo. It's an aggression one sees every day, whether on the cricketing pitches of Australia or in Indian companies buying businesses overseas. It's an aggression that makes us believe in ourselves. Bhagat Singh's life, though it ended at all of 23 at the hands of the British, embodies all that inspires contemporary India. A young man who was the perfect combination of the physical and the intellectual, a man who took to the gun in protest against injustice and then argued his own cause in court. It is a notion of active masculinity that the contemporary Indian would be proud of. It's the same with Bose,



BANDEEP SINGH

a man seen as never allowing himself to be beaten down by circumstances, who travelled far and wide to build an army against the might of the British Empire, failing but doing so honourably.

This special issue is a collection of articles on these 60 greats by experts drawn from across the world. Whether it is Harvard professor Sugata Bose who unravels the mystique of Bose, or West Bengal Governor Gopalkrishna Gandhi who taps into the Gandhi phenomenon (as his youngest grandson he had a ringside view of it), or writer William Radice who distills the spirit of Rabindranath Tagore, I hope the essays will inspire you. These men and women who shaped the temples of modern India and devised the institutions that protect our freedoms have much to teach a nation that may excel in growth indicators but has a long way to go before it acquires the purity of thought and the moral stature of these 60 greatest Indians. It makes the leaders of modern India with their power grubbing ways, their narrow self-interests and insatiable greed a parody in comparison.

I hope after reading this issue you will use the word great with less frequency and certainly with less abandon. I certainly did.

Aroon Purie
(Aroon Purie)